

I want to begin today's meeting with a *mea culpa*, and with a strong statement about my personal commitment to Board procedures, Ohio law, and to transparency.

Out of an abundance of caution, and with a close eye on the number of positive COVID cases in the Middle School and the growing number of students required to stay home from school, through me a majority of the Board – Ms. Kramer, Ms. Wigman and I – recommended that Superintendent Magyar issue a mask mandate for the Middle School, where we've seen more positive COVID-19 cases than any school in our system, other than Highland Drive Elementary. Ms. Mack and Mr. Dosen were not in favor of the Middle School mask recommendation nor did either Ms. Mack or Mr. Dosen participate in the process that led us to our recommendation.

I stand by that recommendation. I looked at the numbers, and as a father and a grandfather, I wanted the District to move quickly to keep these numbers from growing and keep kids and staff in school. I feel passionately about that.

Superintendent Magyar issued a Middle School mask mandate and informed the school community, which she had the authority to do, and which became effective September 15th until further notice. Board policy now permits the Superintendent as well as the Board to make timely decisions about facial coverings for some or all students in the district. But procedurally, in my zeal, I went about it in the wrong way by not having a more transparent process to communicate my concerns and those of Ms. Kramer and Ms. Wigman to our fellow Board members, Ms. Magyar, and to the community, and I want to correct that tonight.

To that end, tonight the Board will discuss and deliberate the issue of Middle School masks, and also consider a resolution to affirm the September 15 mask decision to increase safety measures at the Middle School in order to mitigate against the continued spread of COVID-19. We will also consider a resolution to require masks at the Middle School moving forward from today.

I am absolutely committed to making this gaffe right. It's no secret that there are many things this Board does not agree on – and healthy, objective debate is a good thing – but we all agree that we must be transparent to serve this District and this community to the best of our ability.

I want to back up words with action: Ms. Kramer and Ms. Wigman and I are going to take additional training on Ohio's Open Meetings Act so that we can keep pace with the changing landscape of Ohio's public schools, and to remind ourselves of our ongoing obligation to our community to always act in an open and transparent manner, consistent with Ohio's Sunshine Laws.

I respect and value the interests of our community. I know we all do. So, let's move forward together in the best interest of the District, and more specifically, in the interest of keeping our Middle School kids and staff safely in class.

Thank you, and let's move on with tonight's agenda. I now ask if Ms. Magyar could update us on our COVID-19 dashboard and other relevant data points, so that we can move into an informed deliberation and discussion on this issue.